

# IAM-01: IAM Governance Foundations

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**Series:** IAM — IAM Administration | **Notebook:** 1 of 12 | **Created:** January 2026 |  
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## Building a Strong Foundation for Identity Management

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Effective IAM governance is the cornerstone of enterprise security. This notebook establishes the framework for managing identities, groups, policies, and access controls in Dynatrace's Gen3 IAM system.

**Migrating from Management Zones?** If you have existing Management Zones and need to migrate them to Gen3 Policies and Boundaries, see the **MZ2POL** series instead. This series is for greenfield IAM governance.

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# Prerequisites

| Requirement           | Details                                    |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Dynatrace Environment | SaaS with Gen3 IAM enabled                 |
| Permissions           | Account Administrator or IAM Administrator |
| Knowledge             | Basic understanding of identity concepts   |

## 1. Gen3 IAM Overview

Dynatrace Gen3 IAM replaces the legacy Management Zone-based access control with a modern **Attribute-Based Access Control (ABAC)** model. This provides fine-grained, scalable access management for enterprises.

### Key Components

| Component  | Purpose                                      | Scope                  |
|------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Policies   | Define what actions users can perform        | Account or Environment |
| Boundaries | Filter which entities users can see          | Environment            |
| Buckets    | Physically partition data for team isolation | Environment            |
| Segments   | Reusable DQL-based data filters              | Environment            |
| Groups     | Collections of users with shared access      | Account                |
| Users      | Individual identities (local or federated)   | Account                |

### Data Partitioning Options

Choose the right isolation mechanism for your needs:

| Mechanism  | Isolation Type       | Reversible                                                                              | Best For                          |
|------------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Buckets    | Physical separation  |  No  | Strict team isolation, compliance |
| Boundaries | Query-time filtering |  Yes | Flexible access scoping           |

| Mechanism | Isolation Type       | Reversible | Best For          |
|-----------|----------------------|------------|-------------------|
| Segments  | Query-time filtering | ✅ Yes      | Ad-hoc data views |

⚠️ **Key Decision:** If you need **hard data isolation** between teams (e.g., Team A can never see Team B's data), use **Buckets**. If you need flexible, changeable access controls, use **Boundaries**.

## Why Gen3?

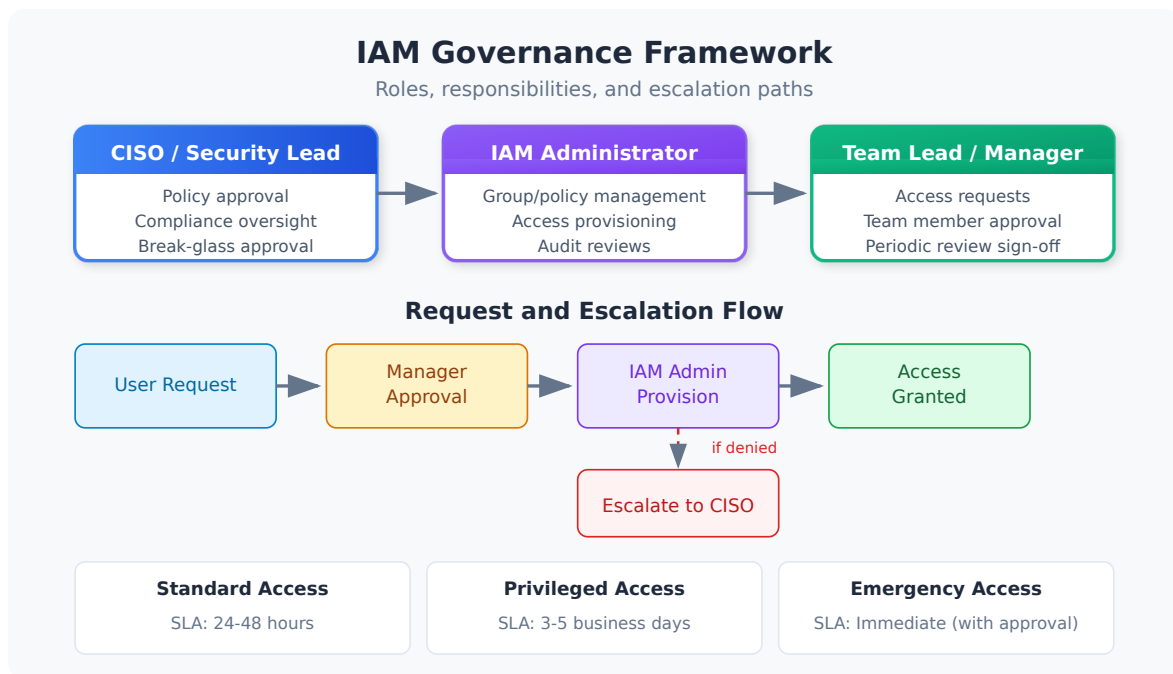
The Gen3 model provides several advantages over legacy Management Zones:

- **Scalability:** Policies and boundaries scale to thousands of entities
- **Flexibility:** Attribute-based rules adapt as your environment changes
- **Separation of Concerns:** Policies (actions) separate from boundaries (visibility)
- **Grail Integration:** Native support for Grail data lakehouse permissions
- **Bucket Partitioning:** Physical data isolation for compliance and team separation

**Note:** If you're migrating from Management Zones, see the **MZ2POL** series for migration guidance. This series assumes you're using Gen3 IAM.

## 2. The ABAC Model

Attribute-Based Access Control (ABAC) evaluates access requests based on attributes rather than static role assignments.



## How Access is Evaluated

When a user attempts an action, Dynatrace evaluates:

1. **Identity:** Who is the user? What groups do they belong to?
2. **Policy:** Does any assigned policy grant this action?
3. **Boundary:** Is the target entity within their boundary conditions?
4. **Segment:** Does the data match their segment filters?

Access is granted only if ALL conditions are satisfied.

## Policy Statement Structure

```
ALLOW <service>:<resource>:<action> [WHERE
<condition>]
```

Example:

```
ALLOW storage:logs:read WHERE storage:dt.security_context = "team-a"
```

## Three Permission Domains

| Domain      | Controls                              | Examples                 |
|-------------|---------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| Environment | Smartscape entities (hosts, services) | View hosts, see topology |
| Storage     | Grail data (logs, spans, metrics)     | Read logs, query spans   |
| Settings    | Configuration objects                 | Edit alerting rules      |

## 3. Governance Roles and Responsibilities

Effective IAM governance requires clear ownership and accountability. Define these roles within your organization.

### Core IAM Roles

| Role                      | Responsibilities                                      | Typical Team        |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|
| Account Administrator     | Manage account-level settings, billing, environments  | Platform Team       |
| IAM Administrator         | Manage groups, policies, boundaries, user access      | Security/IAM Team   |
| Environment Administrator | Manage environment-specific settings and integrations | Platform Team       |
| Security Auditor          | Review access logs, compliance reporting              | Security/Compliance |
| Group Owner               | Manage membership of specific groups                  | Application Teams   |

### Separation of Duties

Implement checks and balances:

| Action                  | Primary   | Approver      |
|-------------------------|-----------|---------------|
| Create new policy       | IAM Admin | Security Lead |
| Add user to admin group | IAM Admin | Account Admin |

| Action                 | Primary   | Approver          |
|------------------------|-----------|-------------------|
| Modify boundaries      | IAM Admin | Environment Owner |
| Create service account | IAM Admin | Application Owner |

## RACI Matrix for IAM Operations

| Activity               | Account Admin | IAM Admin | Env Admin | Auditor |
|------------------------|---------------|-----------|-----------|---------|
| Policy creation        | A             | R         | C         | I       |
| Group management       | I             | R         | C         | I       |
| Access reviews         | A             | R         | C         | R       |
| Compliance reporting   | I             | C         | I         | R       |
| Break-glass procedures | R             | R         | I         | I       |

*R=Responsible, A=Accountable, C=Consulted, I=Informed*

## 4. Account vs Environment Permissions

Understanding the two-tier permission model is critical for proper governance.

### Account Level

Account-level permissions apply across ALL environments:

| Permission          | Grants                                 |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------|
| account-viewer      | View account settings, environments    |
| account-editor      | Modify account settings                |
| account-iam-admin   | Manage users, groups, account policies |
| environment-creator | Create new environments                |

## Environment Level

Environment-level permissions scope to a single environment:

| Permission         | Grants                               |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------|
| environment-viewer | Read-only access to environment data |
| environment-editor | Modify environment configurations    |
| environment-admin  | Full environment control             |
| Custom policies    | Fine-grained access per your design  |

## Best Practice: Least Privilege

Account Level → Minimal, highly restricted  
Environment Level → Scoped to team/function need

### Example Structure:

| User Type      | Account Permission | Environment Permission               |
|----------------|--------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Platform Admin | account-iam-admin  | environment-admin (all)              |
| App Team Lead  | account-viewer     | environment-editor (their env)       |
| Developer      | None               | Custom policy (read + limited write) |
| Auditor        | account-viewer     | environment-viewer (all)             |

## 5. Centralized vs Federated Models

Choose the governance model that fits your organization's structure.

### Centralized Model

A single team controls all IAM operations.

**Characteristics:**

- Central IAM team manages all policies, groups, boundaries

- Consistent standards across the organization
- Single point of control and audit

**Best For:**

- Regulated industries (finance, healthcare)
- Organizations requiring strict compliance
- Smaller deployments (< 500 users)

**Implementation:**

```
Central IAM Team → All policy/group/boundary management
App Teams → Request access via tickets
```

## Federated Model

Distributed ownership with central oversight.

**Characteristics:**

- Business units manage their own groups/boundaries
- Central team sets standards and audits
- Faster response to team needs

**Best For:**

- Large enterprises with autonomous teams
- Organizations with diverse tech stacks
- DevOps/platform engineering models

**Implementation:**

```
Central IAM Team → Policies, standards, audit
Group Owners → Group membership management
Environment Owners → Environment-specific boundaries
```

## Hybrid Model

Most enterprises adopt a hybrid approach:

| Area                   | Ownership        |
|------------------------|------------------|
| Account-level policies | Central IAM team |
| Environment policies   | Central IAM team |



| Area                 | Ownership                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Group membership     | Delegated to group owners            |
| Boundary definitions | Collaborative (central + env owners) |

## 6. Documentation and Change Management

Governance requires documentation and controlled changes.

### Required Documentation

| Document                     | Content                        | Review Frequency |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------|------------------|
| <b>Access Policy</b>         | Who can access what            | Annual           |
| <b>Group Catalog</b>         | All groups, owners, purposes   | Quarterly        |
| <b>Policy Inventory</b>      | All policies with descriptions | Quarterly        |
| <b>Boundary Definitions</b>  | Boundary rules and rationale   | Quarterly        |
| <b>Onboarding Guide</b>      | New user access process        | As needed        |
| <b>Offboarding Checklist</b> | Access revocation steps        | As needed        |

### Change Management Process

All IAM changes should follow a controlled process:

1. **Request:** Ticket with business justification
2. **Review:** IAM admin reviews against policy
3. **Approval:** Required approver signs off
4. **Implementation:** Change made with audit trail
5. **Verification:** Requestor confirms access works
6. **Documentation:** Update catalogs/inventories

### GitOps for IAM

Consider version-controlling your IAM configuration:

```
# policies/team-a-readonly.yaml
name: team-a-readonly
description: Read-only access for Team A
statements:
  - effect: ALLOW
    service: storage
    resource: logs
    action: read
    conditions:
      - storage:dt.security_context = "team-a"
```

Benefits:

- Full audit trail via git history
- Peer review before changes
- Rollback capability
- Documentation as code

See **AUTOM-03: Monaco** for configuration-as-code implementation.

## 7. Governance Assessment

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Use these queries to assess your current IAM governance posture.

```
// Count entities by security context - see how data is partitioned
fetch dt.entity.service
| summarize
  total = count(),
  withContext = countIf(isNotNull(dt.security_context)),
  missingContext = countIf(isNull(dt.security_context))
| fieldsAdd coveragePercent = round(100.0 * withContext / total, decimals: 2)

// Smartscape note (dt.entity.* is deprecated but still functional):
dt.security_context exists
// on Smartscape nodes but as an ARRAY (empty [] when unset, not null), so
isNull / isNotNull
// and by:{dt.security_context} do not carry over – a Smartscape rewrite would
miscount coverage.
// Keep the classic query above.
```

```
// List services without security context (governance gaps)
fetch dt.entity.service
| filter isNull(dt.security_context)
| fields entity.name, tags
| sort entity.name
| limit 50

// Smartscape note (dt.entity.* is deprecated but still functional):
dt.security_context exists
// on Smartscape nodes but as an ARRAY (empty [] when unset, not null), so
isNull / isNotNull
// and by:{dt.security_context} do not carry over – a Smartscape rewrite would
miscount coverage.
// Keep the classic query above.
// (entity tags are also not a flat "tags" field on Smartscape – resolve via
getNodeField.)
```

```
// Review security context distribution
fetch dt.entity.service
| filter isNotNull(dt.security_context)
| summarize serviceCount = count(), by:{dt.security_context}
| sort serviceCount desc
| limit 20

// Smartscape note (dt.entity.* is deprecated but still functional):
dt.security_context exists
// on Smartscape nodes but as an ARRAY (empty [] when unset, not null), so
isNull / isNotNull
// and by:{dt.security_context} do not carry over – a Smartscape rewrite would
miscount coverage.
// Keep the classic query above.
```

```
// Check host security context coverage
fetch dt.entity.host
| summarize
    total = count(),
    withContext = countIf(isNotNull(dt.security_context)),
    missingContext = countIf(isNull(dt.security_context))
| fieldsAdd coveragePercent = round(100.0 * withContext / total, decimals: 2)

// Smartscape note (dt.entity.* is deprecated but still functional):
dt.security_context exists
// on Smartscape nodes but as an ARRAY (empty [] when unset, not null), so
isNull / isNotNull
// and by:{dt.security_context} do not carry over – a Smartscape rewrite would
miscount coverage.
// Keep the classic query above.
```

## Interpreting Results

| Metric                    | Target   | Action if Below         |
|---------------------------|----------|-------------------------|
| Security context coverage | > 95%    | Review tagging strategy |
| Orphaned entities         | < 5%     | Assign ownership        |
| Context distribution      | Balanced | Review boundary design  |

## 8. Next Steps

With governance foundations in place, proceed to implement the specific components:

### Recommended Path

1. **IAM-02: SSO and Authentication** - Configure SSO before users and groups
2. **IAM-03: Group Architecture and Design** - Design your group hierarchy
3. **IAM-04: Policy Authoring and Management** - Create custom policies
4. **IAM-05: Boundary Design Patterns** - Implement data boundaries

## Bonus Workshop

**IAM-11: Policy Persona Workshop** — A hands-on exercise for mapping organizational roles to Dynatrace IAM policies using persona-based design. Recommended after completing the core series.

## Governance Checklist

Before moving on, ensure you have:

- ☐ Identified IAM roles and owners in your organization
- ☐ Chosen centralized, federated, or hybrid model
- ☐ Documented your access policy framework
- ☐ Established a change management process
- ☐ Assessed current security context coverage

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## Summary

In this notebook, you learned:

- The Gen3 IAM model and its components (policies, boundaries, segments)
- How ABAC evaluates access requests
- Core governance roles and their responsibilities
- The difference between account and environment permissions
- Centralized vs federated governance models
- Documentation and change management requirements

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## References

- [IAM Overview](#)
- [Manage User Permissions with Policies](#)

- [Account Management](#)

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*This notebook was AI-generated from community-submitted and publicly available sources. This notebook series is not officially supported by Dynatrace. Always verify information against official Dynatrace documentation.*